They contain popular works such as *Theragatha and Therigatha* (Hymns of the Elder Monks and Nuns) and *Jataka* tales (Buddha's deeds in previous births as *Bodhisattva*).

Other important Buddhist works include *Milinda Panha*, a discussion between Greco-Bactrian king Menander and Buddhist monk Nagasena, and Ceylonese chronicles *Dipavamsa* (Island Chronicles), *Mahavamsa* (Great Chronicle) and *Culavamsa* (Lesser Chronicle).

Four Noble Truths of Buddha

The four noble truths prescribed by Buddha are as follows:

1. The Noble Truth of Suffering: Birth, age, death, unpleasantness, separation, unfulfilled wish.
2. The Noble Truth of the Origin of Suffering: thirst for pleasure, power, long life, etc. are the causes for sorrow.
3. The Noble Truth of the Cessation of Suffering (*Nirvana*): complete stopping or release from sorrow.
4. The Noble Truth of the Path Leading to Cessation of Suffering: the Noble Eight fold Path or the Middle Path.

Buddha's Middle or Eightfold Path (Astangika Marga)

(1) Right Views; (2) Right Resolve; (3) Right Speech; (4) Right Conduct; (5) Right Livelihood; (6) Right Effort; (7) Right Recollection; (8) Right Meditation.

Hence Buddha did not mention or talk about God. He neither accepted nor denied the existence of God. Buddhism advocated equality. It preached non-violence or *ahimsa* and love towards all. However, it was a moderate religion compared to Jainism's insistence on *ahimsa*. It promoted trade and capitalism as it was against waste and advocated frugality. Jobs involving any form of killing were forbidden. Trade in weapons, living beings, meat, liquor and poison were not permitted.

Buddhism in Tamilnadu

Buddhism spread to Tamizhagam from about third century BCE. Asokan inscriptions found in the Deccan region vouch for the spread of Buddhism to southern parts of India. Archaeological evidences also reveal the existence of a Buddhist complex of the fourth century CE in Kaveripattinam. Quoting *Pattinapalai*, Noboru Karashima refers to merchants in Kaveripoompattinam, who were vegetarians, opposed to animal sacrifice. From this one could presume the influence of Buddhism in Tamil country. *Manimekalai* by *Sattanar* one of the twin epics of the post-Sangam age is a Buddhist literature. Similarly the now extinct *Kundalakesi* is a Buddhist epic. Kanchipuram in the early Christian era was a flourishing Buddhist centre. Dinnaga and Dharmapala, who headed the famous Nalanda University were renowned Buddhist scholars from Kanchipuram. Hiuen Tsang who visited Tamil country mentions in his travel accounts about several Buddhist Stupas built by Asoka in Kanchipuram.

A Buddhist temple was built in Nagapattinam at the request of a Chinese ruler during the reign of Pallava king Narasimhavarman II (CE 695-722). Chinese monk Wu-hing visited the monastery. In CE 1006, during the reign of Rajaraja I, Srivijaya King Mara-wijayottungga-varman built a Buddhist temple in Nagapattinam. It is called the Soolamani-varma-vihara.

Decline of Buddhism in India

Buddhism faced divisions from time to time. Division into various splinter groups like 'Hinayana', 'Mahayana', 'Vajrayana', 'Tantrayana' and 'Sahajayana' led Buddhism to lose its originality. Pali and Prakrit were the spoken languages of people of north India and it was through these languages the message of Buddhism was spread. But ever since the times of Fourth Buddhist Council held during the reign of Kanishka, Sanskrit had come to be adopted. Buddhism thereupon became unintelligible to common people.

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